

Focus professional learning communities on curriculum

BY STEPHANIE HIRSH

Grade-level, subject-specific professional learning communities are the vehicle for achieving the promise of high-quality curriculum. Surveys have found that teachers regularly supplement and modify district curricula or use materials that they or their colleagues developed (Kane, Owens, Marinell, Thal, & Staiger, 2016; Opfer, Kaufman, & Thompson, 2016). Professional learning communities have the potential to ensure that those decisions are made carefully and in ways that increase coherence and learning across classrooms within a school.

At the same time, they also have the potential to ensure that the best ideas are shared across community members' classrooms rather than confined to a single classroom. In this way, well-structured professional learning communities can help advance equity for all students in a school and, when implemented consistently across all schools, within a school district.

GREEN DOT PUBLIC SCHOOLS

Instruction Partners, a nonprofit that works with teachers and leaders to strengthen instruction and unlock student potential, recently published a white paper examining the experiences of schools implementing rigorous curricula.

One of the sites it works with is Green Dot Public Schools in Memphis, Tennessee. At Green Dot, teachers use an alternating structure for their work.

One week a month, teachers work in grade-level teams using a protocol to unpack an upcoming lesson together. During this time, teachers focus on preparing a lesson, such as solving the math problems they will present to students, anticipating where students might get stuck and how to support them without watering down rigor, and how to guide text-based discussions.

In the other weeks, teachers review student work from the lesson they had planned together and analyze the work to refine their instructional practice. They might look at exit ticket data, examine common assessment data for trends, and pinpoint opportunities for reteaching or things to keep in mind as they move forward to the next unit.

Green Dot is doing this in grade-specific learning teams across its network of five schools, and it has selected curriculum leads — expert teachers from each grade — to facilitate.

Teachers work closely with the curriculum lead to determine which lessons are must-do versus may-do, pacing, and which questions to make anchor questions across classrooms. Green Dot continues to make adjustments to its approach in response to teacher feedback, such as shifting



from virtual to in-person meetings.

“I think teachers definitely learn best when they learn from one another,” says Chrystie Edwards, director of academics for Green Dot in Memphis. “One of the best outcomes that we didn’t anticipate was the productive struggle for adults ... for one teacher to see another teacher struggle and persist, and to see the corresponding increase in achievement data is a motivator beyond no other. We’re starting to see pockets of that.”

Instead of spending their time writing lessons from scratch or searching for materials online, teachers can now go deeper into content and understanding how to meet each student’s needs. They then are positioned to modify and supplement the lessons in ways that increase coherence and learning. And by reviewing student work and assessing what is working together, they can advance equity.

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